Dorian and Irina Bibescu: A Spiritual Community Between Transylvania and the Mercantour

An account of an esoteric community between Romania, France and Italy

Dorian and Irina Bibescu were a Romanian couple involved in spiritualist and esoteric practices who, during the 1990s, divided their lives between France and Romania. Having led several spiritual communities in Romania, they left the country shortly after the fall of Nicolae Ceaușescu's communist regime in 1990 and settled in France. They chose Tende, a mountain village in the Alpes-Maritimes, surrounded by a landscape particularly rich in history, traditions, and stories associated with esotericism.

Their choice of Tende appears to have been far from accidental. The village lies close to the Vallée des Merveilles, famous for its thousands of prehistoric rock engravings and for the particular atmosphere that certain esoteric and spiritual traditions associate with the area. Deeply attracted to ancient forms of spirituality, shamanism, and pre-Christian traditions, Irina and Dorian considered the Mercantour an ideal setting in which to develop their practices.

It was in this region that they reportedly established two separate communities, whose members were carefully selected. The first followers were mainly of Russian origin. The historical presence of Russian communities in the Alpes-Maritimes and, more broadly, in Provence facilitated some of these connections. French and Italian members subsequently joined them, with the proximity of the Italian border naturally encouraging exchanges between the two countries.

Irina's community was primarily devoted to shamanic practices and rituals inspired by ancient spiritual traditions. Some ceremonies were reportedly held at night in the Vallée des Merveilles, in natural locations regarded as particularly powerful on a symbolic or energetic level. Dorian's rituals, meanwhile, took place in a space arranged inside an old house in Limone Piemonte, Italy, roughly twenty kilometres from Tende.

Each group reportedly had around fifteen members, with several people belonging to both communities. Irina's group was nevertheless predominantly female. It included only three or four men, among them her husband, Dorian.

The community's activities were also strongly seasonal. From November to February, the Bibescus lived in Tende, while the rest of the year they returned to Sibiu, Romania. Winter in the Mercantour is particularly harsh, with very low temperatures and difficult weather conditions. Yet this period had one major advantage in Irina's view: the relative absence of tourists. The reduced visitor numbers allowed the ceremonies to be conducted with greater discretion and, in their eyes, in an environment more conducive to contemplation.

The initiations held in the Mercantour were reportedly particularly demanding. They combined physical challenges with exercises intended to test the participants' mental and psychological resilience. The winter conditions, isolation, and nature of the ceremonies made these experiences especially difficult. Few followers were said to have completed the entire initiation process, with some leaving the community within the first few days.

Dorian’s practices appear to have been less physically demanding but more focused on psychological and inner work. Although the two communities differed in their methods and organization, they nevertheless shared a common approach to spirituality, centred on the pursuit of mystical experiences, initiation, and the confrontation of the individual with his or her own limits.

For several years, these groups apparently operated in relative secrecy, moving between the mountains of the Mercantour and the lands of Transylvania. Their presence remained largely unknown to the general public and only became a subject of particular curiosity after they disappeared.

In 2015, Dorian and Irina Bibescu, along with several of their followers, reportedly ceased to make themselves known. The disappearance of the couple and some members of the communities fuelled various rumours. In the absence of clear information, some people suggested the possibility of a collective tragedy and even drew parallels with the Order of the Solar Temple, whose collective deaths and suicides had deeply affected European esoteric circles during the 1990s.

Such comparisons nevertheless remain, at this stage, matters of rumour and speculation. They have nonetheless contributed to the mysterious reputation surrounding the communities of Dorian and Irina Bibescu: groups associated with shamanic practices, nocturnal rituals, ancient spiritual traditions, and an unexplained disappearance.